

# Engineering Incident Response Playbook

|                |                        |                |            |
|----------------|------------------------|----------------|------------|
| Policy ID      | AF-ENG-007             | Version        | 1.0        |
| Owner          | Engineering Operations | Effective Date | 2026-01-01 |
| Classification | Internal - Demo Corpus | Review Cycle   | Annual     |

## Document Purpose

This synthetic company document is designed for testing enterprise retrieval, grounded question answering, cross-document comparison, citation mapping, and evaluation workflows in NexusIQ.

## 1. Purpose and Incident Definition

The Engineering Incident Response Playbook defines how ApexFlow Technologies detects, triages, escalates, resolves, and reviews production incidents. An incident is any event that degrades system reliability, security, customer experience, data integrity, or service availability.

- The playbook applies to production systems, customer-facing APIs, data pipelines, authentication, billing, and internal operational tools.
- Incident response is coordinated through the #incident-response channel and the on-call rotation.
- All SEV1 and SEV2 incidents require a written postmortem.

## 2. Severity Levels

| Severity | Customer Impact                 | Examples                                                                                                       |
|----------|---------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| SEV1     | Critical impact or broad outage | Authentication outage, billing unavailable, data loss risk, security event, or platform-wide API failure.      |
| SEV2     | Major degraded experience       | High latency, partial feature outage, regional service issue, failed background jobs affecting many customers. |
| SEV3     | Limited or internal impact      | Small customer group affected, delayed report generation, non-critical internal dashboard failure.             |

A SEV1 incident must be acknowledged by the primary on-call engineer within 10 minutes and escalated to the incident commander immediately.

## 3. Roles and Responsibilities

- Primary On-Call Engineer: acknowledges alerts, starts triage, and opens the incident channel.
- Incident Commander: coordinates the response, assigns roles, manages timeline updates, and decides when to escalate.
- Communications Lead: posts customer and stakeholder updates every 30 minutes for SEV1 and every 60 minutes for SEV2.
- Subject Matter Expert: investigates the affected service, deploys fixes, reviews logs, and validates recovery.
- Scribe: records timeline, decisions, mitigation steps, and unresolved follow-up items.

## 4. Escalation Workflow

Escalation should happen when the primary responder cannot identify the cause within the expected triage window, when customer impact expands, when security or data integrity is involved, or when a fix requires another team.

| Trigger            | Escalation Time | Action                                                                      |
|--------------------|-----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| SEV1 acknowledged  | Immediate       | Assign incident commander and notify engineering leadership.                |
| SEV2 unresolved    | 30 minutes      | Escalate to service owner and platform lead.                                |
| Security concern   | Immediate       | Notify Security and Compliance lead.                                        |
| Customer data risk | Immediate       | Notify Data Platform owner and Legal liaison.                               |
| No clear owner     | 15 minutes      | Incident commander assigns temporary owner and requests leadership support. |

## 5. Resolution, Validation, and Communication

A fix is not considered complete until the affected service is stable, dashboards show recovery, error rates return to baseline, and the incident commander confirms customer impact has ended. The communications lead must post a final update that summarizes impact, mitigation, and remaining follow-up work.

- SEV1 status updates: every 30 minutes until resolved.
- SEV2 status updates: every 60 minutes until resolved.
- SEV3 updates: posted when the owner starts work and when the issue is resolved.

## 6. Postmortem Requirements

All SEV1 and SEV2 incidents require a postmortem within 5 business days. The postmortem must include customer impact, timeline, root cause, contributing factors, detection gap, resolution steps, action items, owners, and due dates. SEV3 incidents require a postmortem only when requested by engineering leadership or when the same issue repeats within 30 days.

Postmortem action items must be tracked until completion. Repeated missed action items are escalated to the engineering director.